

Paper 2: Religion and Ethics

Overview

The content for this paper is focused on exploring both common ground and controversy in dealing with issues that arise in the areas of morality and religion in the context of the modern world. The paper will help students to study some of the underlying ideas and concepts of these issues, as well as questions and issues about how ethical and religious ideas and solutions may be applied in practice in contemporary social, political and personal situations. The study addresses an important part of the key underlying concerns that students raise about the world in which they are growing up, and about their own views, opinions and commitments.

In this paper, students will study issues and practical problems such as equality, war and peace and sexual ethics. These issues and problems will provide a sufficient balance of breadth and depth for students to acquire the skills they need to address a wide range of contemporary moral dilemmas and to progress to further study. A representative array of ethical stances provides a basis for discussion and debate about major issues. This is further sharpened by engagement with the views and stances of significant ethical thinkers who have contributed to the debates.

Students will extend the breadth and depth of their study by engaging in debates about how underlying factors, such as language, are relevant in discussing moral issues, and whether there is common ground between religion and morality. This element is considered in the wider context of influences that have helped to shape modern ethical theory. Students at this level will consider, and respond to, the contrasting views of key scholars to broaden their awareness of the underlying issues. **These studies will give students the opportunity to explore links between this paper and other areas of study, such as issues about concepts in relation to philosophy or about beliefs and values in relation to the study of a particular religion.** A strong focus on understanding ethical theory is applied at this level to issues in medical ethics, considered in the context of debates about the beginning and ending of life.

It is compulsory for students to compare the work of two named scholars, including a specific extract of their work. The list of extracts at the end of the paper must be studied by all students and this includes the work of two named scholars for comparison. These are published in the *A level Religious Studies Anthology: Paper 2 – Religion and Ethics*, which can be downloaded from our website. The context in which these texts could be studied is indicated by bracketed numbers in the detailed content, (1) for example. These extracts are **not** exclusive to the topic areas under which they appear; students will need to be able to apply these extracts across any suitable topic.

This allows for a range of questions, including text or language specific, as well as thematic.

In this paper, students will be required to study the ideas of key contributors in relation to specific content areas. These are indicated against each relevant sub-topic. Students will be required to use these ideas to support and underpin their knowledge and understanding.

Overall, this study will provide engaging, contemporary and relevant study for students on whichever course they choose to embark in higher or further education, or whatever career they may choose to follow.

Topics	What students need to learn	
1 Significant concepts in issues or debates in religion and ethics	1.1	Environmental issues a) Concepts of stewardship and conservation from the point of view of at least one religion and at least one secular ethical perspective; animal welfare and protection, sustainability, waste management and climate change. b) Strengths and weaknesses of significant areas of disagreement and debate, assessment of relevant examples, legal changes and social attitudes, appropriateness and value of employing religious perspectives in these debates. With reference to the ideas of J Lovelock and A Næss.
	1.2	Equality a) Ethical and religious concepts of equality, including the issues of gender or race or disability and the work of one significant figure in campaigns for equality in the chosen area, significant events in the progress of equality in these areas, perspectives on equality from at least one religion and one secular ethical perspective. b) Strengths and weaknesses of significant areas of disagreement and debate, assessment of relevant examples, legal changes and social attitudes, appropriateness and value of employing religious perspectives into these debates. With reference to the ideas of Martin Luther King and Joni Eareckson Tada.